

Political Shocks, Interstate Migration, and Geographic Polarization*

Jonas Adolph and Knut Niemann

September 2026

Abstract

Geographic political sorting has intensified in the United States, raising the question whether political events shape internal migration in ways that reinforce it. Combining annual county-to-county Internal Revenue Service migration flows with 45 U.S. gubernatorial elections decided by less than five percentage points between 1994 and 2014, we compare locally losing and winning counties in stacked event studies. During the first five post-election years, outmigration from losing counties rises by 3.21 percent relative to winning counties. Conditional on total departures and destination shocks, migration from losing counties shifts by 4.02 percent toward strongholds of the losing party relative to winner-party strongholds. The increase in outmigration is concentrated in races with large candidate-ideology gaps, consistent with larger political shocks moving more residents across the migration threshold. A migration-selection model rationalizes both margins, while gravity estimates showing less migration between politically distant states provide corroborating evidence. Together, the results show that political events can redirect internal migration in a direction consistent with greater geographic sorting.

*Adolph: University of Tübingen, jonas-daniel.adolph@uni-tuebingen.de. Niemann: University of Tübingen, knut.niemann@uni-tuebingen.de. We thank Gernot Müller, Peter Eppinger, Wilhelm Kohler, Thomas Krause, and participants at the research seminar in Aachen, the XXVII Conference on International Economics, and the Tübingen–Hohenheim Economics Workshop for useful comments. Elias Teutschländer and Selami Doğan Akansu provided excellent research assistance.

1 Introduction

Spatial political polarization has intensified in the United States and other countries (Kaplan et al. 2022; Huijsmans and Rodden 2025). Residential mobility may contribute if political events change who leaves and where movers go. Yet evidence on these responses remains limited. In this paper, we quantify them.

For the empirical analysis, we combine county-to-county Internal Revenue Service migration flows with returns from 45 U.S. gubernatorial elections held between 1994 and 2014 and decided by less than five percentage points. These elections form a staggered sequence of state-level shocks. Within each election, counties that supported the statewide loser form the treatment group and those that supported the winner form the comparison group. We estimate stacked event studies around these elections.

Political defeat changes who leaves and where they go. During the first five post-election years, outmigration from losing counties rises by 3.21 percent relative to winning counties. Conditional on total origin outmigration and destination shocks, migration toward strongholds of the losing party rises by 4.02 percent relative to migration toward winner-party strongholds. Political shocks therefore change not only how many people move but also where they go.

The outmigration response is concentrated in elections with ideologically distant candidates, consistent with larger political shocks moving more residents across the migration threshold. This heterogeneity does not provide a separate causal design.

To rationalize the findings, we use a migration-selection model in which individuals choose locations based on amenities, moving costs, and political match. An adverse outcome can push mismatched residents across the threshold for leaving and, conditional on moving, toward better-matched destinations. The model connects both margins within a common framework.

Finally, a gravity exercise shows that politically closer states exchange more migrants. Because political distance is observational, we treat this as corroborating evidence rather than a second causal design.

Together, these results show that political events affect whether and where people move. Departures rise in losing counties, and migration shifts toward destinations aligned with the losing party. This force operates in the direction of greater geographic sorting.

In more detail, governors influence taxes, education, health care, labor-market regulation, and other components of the state policy bundle. A narrow statewide result exposes all residents to the same government, while county returns reveal places differently aligned with that outcome. We use returns from Algara and Amlani (2021) to identify 45 Democratic–Republican elections between 1994 and 2014 with statewide margins below five percentage points. Both parties win close races in early and late sample years, the elections span all major U.S. regions, and some states appear more than once. For each election, a county is treated if its plurality supported the statewide loser; counties that supported the winner form the comparison group. Closeness makes the winner plausibly difficult to anticipate, but it is a sample restriction rather than the basis of a regression-discontinuity design.

Annual county-to-county migration flows come from Internal Revenue Service tax records (Internal Revenue Service 2026). Changes in tax-return addresses identify movements and report the associated numbers of returns and exemptions whenever flows exceed a time-varying disclosure threshold. We use exemptions as our main measure of migrants and returns as an alternative measure. These administrative data provide broad coverage and reveal both total departures from each origin and the destinations chosen by movers. They describe flows rather than population stocks and do not contain individual political affiliation.

We organize the elections in a stacked event study. Each election defines a comparison between locally losing and winning counties from four years before through eight years after the election. County–election fixed effects absorb persistent differences within a stack, and election–year fixed effects absorb shocks common to counties exposed to the same election. Identification comes from differential changes in migration from locally losing counties after the election. We estimate the event-time coefficients by Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood, which accommodates zero flows and the multiplicative conditional mean (Silva and Tenreiro 2006; Correia et al. 2020).

The first outcome is total interstate outmigration from an origin county, irrespective of destination. For the second, we retain bilateral flows and classify destinations as strongholds of the statewide winner’s party, strongholds of the losing party, or swing states. Origin–year–election fixed effects absorb total outmigration, and destination–year–election fixed effects absorb contemporaneous destination shocks. The resulting contrast asks whether migration from losing counties shifts toward loser-party destinations relative to winner-party destinations.

An increase in outmigration alone need not imply political sorting, while destination composition can change without a rise in total mobility. Estimating both margins distinguishes a general response from politically directed reallocation.

For total outmigration, the event-study coefficients are close to zero before the election and become positive afterward. Outmigration from losing counties rises by 3.21 percent over event years zero through four and by 3.68 percent over years zero through eight. The five-year average has a p -value of 0.072, and the joint-path p -value is 0.255 over this window. Over nine post-election years, the average-effect p -value is 0.068 and the path is jointly significant. We therefore interpret the volume evidence as persistent but less precise than the destination evidence.

The destination-composition result is stronger. During the first five post-election years, migration from losing counties toward loser-party strongholds rises by 4.02 percent relative to migration toward winner-party strongholds. The average-effect and joint-path p -values are 0.015 and 0.032, respectively, with no evidence of differential pre-trends in the baseline. Comparing destinations within the same origin, year, and election makes the estimate independent of the increase in total departures and of shocks common to an origin or destination. Classifications based on preceding gubernatorial elections and on presidential voting produce similar qualitative patterns.

We probe whether realized closeness merely selects elections that happened to have small final margins. For the 30 baseline elections covered by professional forecasts, we compare the realized-margin sample with a definition based on final pre-election ratings. Further checks use alternative election universes, non-overlapping stacks, and leave-one-out estimates by election, state, and election year. The destination result is stable across individual elections, while the magnitude and precision of total outmigration are more sensitive to particular races and cohorts. We report this influence explicitly rather than treating the 45 election stacks as interchangeable replications.

Candidate ideology provides a suggestive test of the political channel. We use campaign-finance-based composite scores from the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME) (Bonica 2014), which cover both nominees in 32 elections. The five-year outmigration response is 8.89 percent in above-median-gap races and -1.42 percent in below-median-gap races; the 10.46 percentage-point difference has a p -value of 0.031. Continuous-gap and leave-one-out estimates yield the same qualitative pattern. This concentration is consistent with a larger change

in the expected policy bundle moving more residents across the migration threshold. The corresponding destination contrast is positive but imprecise. Because 13 elections lack scores and the groups differ in their joint pre-election paths, the heterogeneity is not independently causal.

The migration-selection model rationalizes both findings. Individuals differ in political preferences and choose among locations with different conventional amenities and political environments, subject to moving costs. Political defeat lowers the value of remaining for residents who are poorly matched with the new government. Some cross the moving threshold, raising departures from the origin. Among those who leave, political preferences tilt choices toward better-matched destinations. The model thus links selective departure and destination choice within a common framework and clarifies why either margin alone is insufficient to establish a sorting mechanism.

The model also predicts less migration between politically distant states, conditional on conventional determinants of bilateral migration. We examine this implication in a state-to-state gravity model with geographic and historical controls. The estimated relationship is negative and remains so across the main specifications. Because political distance in this exercise is observational rather than quasi-random, we treat the gravity result as corroborating evidence rather than a second causal design.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes gubernatorial institutions, the election sample, and the migration data. Section 3 presents the event-study results, validation exercises, and heterogeneity by candidate ideology. Section 4 develops the migration-selection model, and Section 4.2 examines bilateral political distance in a gravity framework. The final section concludes.

Contribution to the literature. This paper relates most directly to research on the political determinants of migration. Political alignment predicts bilateral migration, politically misaligned residents relocate after salient events, and gubernatorial control affects inflows of particular workers (Tam Cho et al. 2013; Efthyvoulou et al. 2023; Pickard et al. 2022; Downey and Liu 2026). We identify both migration margins within the same shock. Comparing locally losing and winning counties exposed to one statewide outcome separates political defeat from persistent differences across Democratic and Republican places; administrative flows reveal both departures and destination choice.

A related literature studies internal migration and location choice. Households choose among places offering different wages, housing costs, amenities, taxes, and public goods (Tiebout 1956; Diamond 2016; Jia et al. 2023), and migration responds to environmental quality, taxation, and social benefits (Banzhaf and Walsh 2008; Moretti and Wilson 2017; Fiva 2009). We show that political control is another location-specific attribute associated with migration. The close-election design connects changes in this attribute to departures, while bilateral flows separate leaving from destination choice.

The paper also contributes to research on geographic partisan sorting. Voter records document increasing residential segregation alongside substantial within-community heterogeneity (Kaplan et al. 2022; Brown and Enos 2021). Movers sometimes select congruent destinations, but constraints limit this tendency, and mobility explains only a modest share of the historical increase (Mummolo and Nall 2017; Martin and Webster 2020; Brown, Cantoni, et al. 2025). We identify a narrower mechanism: political defeat induces departures and redirects migration toward places aligned with the losing party, without claiming to quantify its aggregate contribution.

Finally, the paper extends research on political control. Close victories change policy, and gubernatorial institutions affect taxes, spending, and labor markets (Lee et al. 2004; Besley and Case 1995; Beland 2015). We show that residents also respond through location choice. A common statewide outcome combined with heterogeneous local alignment links political control to migration without cross-sectional comparisons across governments.

Taken together, the paper treats political outcomes as shocks to the relative attractiveness of places. Evidence on departures, destinations, and candidate ideology shows how political events shape internal migration in a direction consistent with geographic sorting.

2 Data

2.1 Institutional setting

Governors are the chief executives of U.S. states. They propose budgets, administer state agencies, appoint officials, issue executive orders, and sign or veto legislation. Gubernatorial control can therefore affect taxes, public spending, education, labor-market regulation, Medicaid, environmental policy, gun regulation, and abortion access. A change in the governor’s party alters an economically and socially consequential policy portfolio, not only symbolic representation (Besley and Case 1995; Beland 2015).

The 2014 Kansas election illustrates the treatment. Republican incumbent Sam Brownback defended income-tax reductions, opposed Medicaid expansion, and supported conservative positions on abortion and firearms. Democratic challenger Paul Davis opposed further tax cuts, favored greater education spending, and differed on the same social policies. Brownback’s narrow victory exposed every county to one statewide government, but that government was less congruent with the revealed preferences of counties that supported Davis. The treatment captures this relative mismatch.

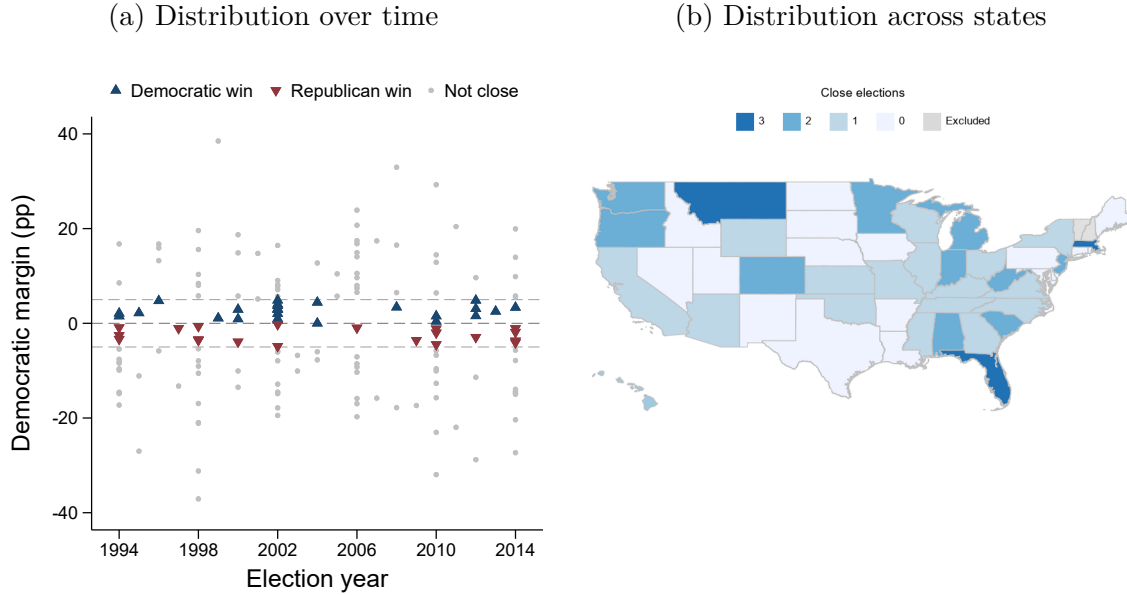
The analysis does not assign the migration response to a particular policy. An election changes expectations about policies, administrative decisions, and political representation, some of which materialize only after inauguration. The estimates capture the response to this bundle. Their dynamics help distinguish an immediate reaction to electoral defeat from gradual adjustment as policies take effect.

2.2 Gubernatorial elections

County-level gubernatorial returns come from Algara and Amlani (2021). We aggregate Democratic, Republican, and third-party votes to determine the statewide winner and margin. County returns identify whether each local plurality supported the statewide winner or loser.

The baseline classifies an election as close when the Democratic–Republican statewide vote-share difference is below five percentage points in absolute value. We consider regularly scheduled elections in states with four-year gubernatorial terms. Alaska is excluded because changes in its boroughs and census areas prevent a con-

Figure 1: The gubernatorial-election sample



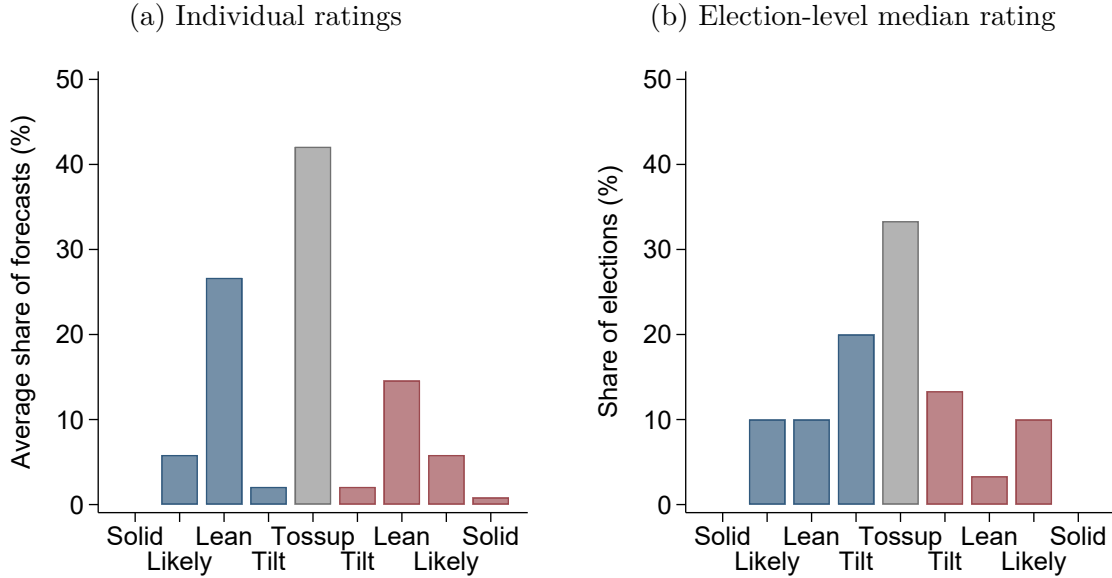
Notes: Panel (a) shows all elections in the working baseline universe. Close Democratic and Republican victories are blue and red; other eligible elections are grey. Dashed lines mark the ± 5 percentage-point cutoff. Panel (b) counts the 45 baseline close elections by state. Alaska is excluded from the map; New Hampshire and Vermont are marked as excluded. Hawaii appears as an inset.

sistent match to IRS migration flows. New Hampshire and Vermont have two-year terms and hence repeated treatments within an event window. We also omit Louisiana in 2003 because its post-election period overlaps with Hurricane Katrina and the associated population displacement.

Narrow statewide outcomes focus the analysis on races in which either party could plausibly win. They make the realized governor more difficult to anticipate and avoid comparing the political environments surrounding close races with those surrounding landslides. Within each state and election, we compare counties that supported the loser with counties that supported the winner. Closeness strengthens this comparison but does not guarantee random assignment or parallel trends. We therefore examine pre-election dynamics, ex ante forecasts, alternative election definitions, and sensitivity to individual stacks.

Figure 1 shows the sample over time and across states. Close victories by both parties occur in early and late years, so winner identity is not mechanically tied to time. The 2002 cohort is unusually large, however. Leave-one-year-out estimates show

Figure 2: Professional forecasts for close gubernatorial elections



Notes: The figure uses the final pre-election rating from each professional forecaster for the 30 baseline close elections with forecast coverage. Panel (a) shows the average distribution of ratings, weighting each election equally; it contains 109 forecaster–election ratings. Panel (b) shows the distribution of the median rating across elections. Democratic ratings are shown in blue, tossups in grey, and Republican ratings in red. Forecasters do not all use identical categories: we standardize “Leans” to “Lean” and combine “Safe” and “Solid,” while retaining “Tilt” as a separate category where it is reported.

its influence, and alternative samples separate midterm elections from elections held in other years.

The elections span all major U.S. regions, but geographic coverage is uneven: some states contribute no close race and others contribute repeated events. We consequently report leave-one-state-out estimates and a sample of non-overlapping election stacks.

Figure 2 compares realized closeness with ex ante competitiveness. Forecasts cover 30 baseline elections. In 20 races, or 66.7 percent, the median final rating was Tossup or Tilt; none had a median Solid rating. The remaining ten were rated Lean or Likely despite final margins below five percentage points. We therefore use forecast ratings as an alternative definition of competitive elections.

Forecast coverage begins in 2002 and does not establish whether the realized winner was correctly predicted. In the robustness analysis, we first reproduce the realized-margin specification on the covered sample and then replace realized closeness

with forecast competitiveness. This separates the alternative definition from the shorter sample period.

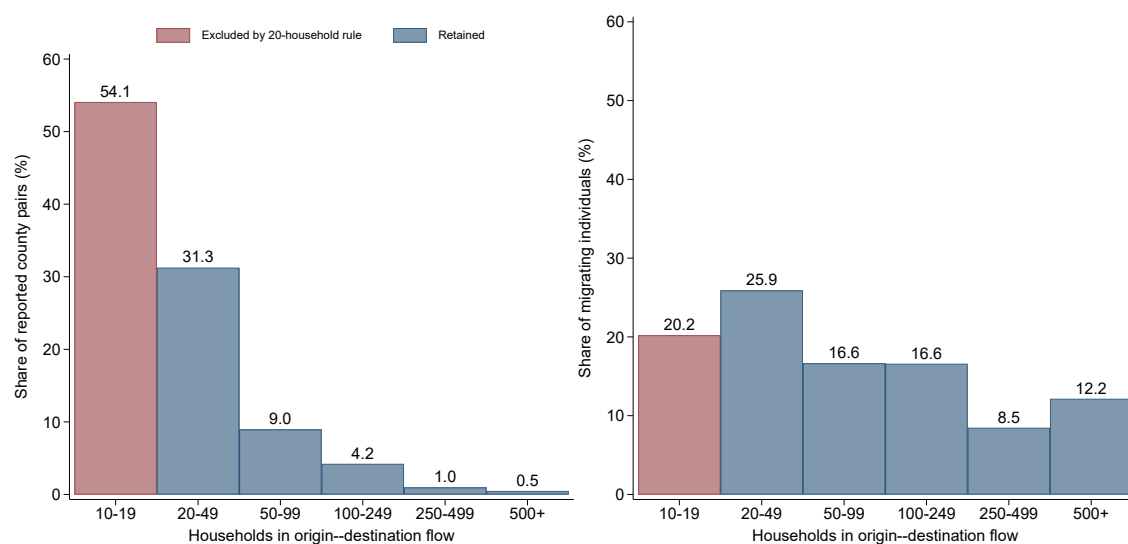
Candidate ideological distance. For the heterogeneity analysis, we link both major-party nominees to version 4.0 of the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME). Its campaign-finance-based composite scores place candidates on a common scale (Bonica 2014). Candidate distance is the absolute difference between the two scores. DIME covers both nominees in 32 baseline elections. Splitting at the median distance of 4.506 yields 16 small-gap and 16 large-gap races. Because coverage is incomplete and need not be random, the exercise describes heterogeneity within the linked sample rather than a new treatment design.

2.3 Migration

Annual county-to-county migration flows come from the Internal Revenue Service’s Statistics of Income program (Internal Revenue Service 2026). Address changes identify moves; returns approximate households and exemptions approximate individuals. Hauer and Byars (2019) describe the series, and DeWaard et al. (2021) document changes affecting comparability after 2011.

Figure 3 shows the distribution of reported flows in 2012, the final year before the reporting-rule change. Links containing 10–19 households account for 54.1 percent of observed county pairs but only 20.2 percent of migrating individuals. A common minimum of 20 households therefore removes many small links while retaining 79.8 percent of reported individual migration. The distribution is descriptive and need not apply identically in every year.

Figure 3: Distribution of reported interstate county-to-county migration flows, 2012



Notes: The figure covers 56,028 reported interstate county-to-county flows in 2012, representing 3,831,729 migrating individuals. Flow-size bins are defined by the number of tax returns, interpreted as households. The left panel reports the share of observed county pairs in each bin; the right panel reports the share of migrating individuals accounted for by those pairs. The red bin contains flows excluded when imposing the harmonized minimum of 20 households.

Table 1: Numerical example of the two migration comparisons

Origin county	Period	Loser destinations	Winner destinations
Locally losing (treated)	Before	100	100
Locally losing (treated)	After	108	104
Locally winning (control)	Before	100	100
Locally winning (control)	After	101	101

Notes: The values are illustrative and are chosen to distinguish the total-outmigration response from the change in destination composition.

2.4 Numerical example

Before introducing the econometric specifications, a numerical example distinguishes the two empirical comparisons. The first concerns total outmigration from losing relative to winning counties. The second concerns the composition of those flows across destination types.

Table 1 considers one losing and one winning county. For the total-outmigration comparison, we sum flows across destination types. Total outmigration rises from 200 to 212 in the treated county, an increase of 6%, and from 200 to 202 in the control county, an increase of 1%. The multiplicative difference-in-differences estimate is therefore

$$\frac{212/200}{202/200} - 1 = 5.0\%.$$

The implied effect on total outmigration from the losing county is therefore 5.0%.

The destination-composition comparison instead asks how migration is distributed between the two destination types. In the treated county, the ratio of migration to loser-party rather than winner-party destinations rises from $100/100 = 1$ before the election to $108/104$ afterward. This ratio remains one in the control county. The corresponding relative change is

$$\frac{(108/104)/(100/100)}{(101/101)/(100/100)} - 1 = 3.8\%.$$

Migration from the losing county toward loser-party destinations therefore rises by 3.8% relative to migration toward winner-party destinations. The first estimate concerns how many people leave; the second concerns where they go. Their magnitudes are not mechanically linked.

3 Political shocks and migration

This section estimates how close electoral losses affect migration. We first ask whether more residents leave counties that supported the losing candidate. We then ask whether, conditional on total outmigration, flows shift toward destinations aligned with the losing party. Both analyses use the same election stacks, treatment definition, and event window; their observation units and fixed effects differ.

3.1 Empirical framework

For each election, the event window runs from four years before through eight years after the vote. Event year -1 is omitted. We estimate both specifications by PPML and cluster standard errors at the level of the absorbed bilateral unit.

Total outmigration. For the volume margin, we estimate

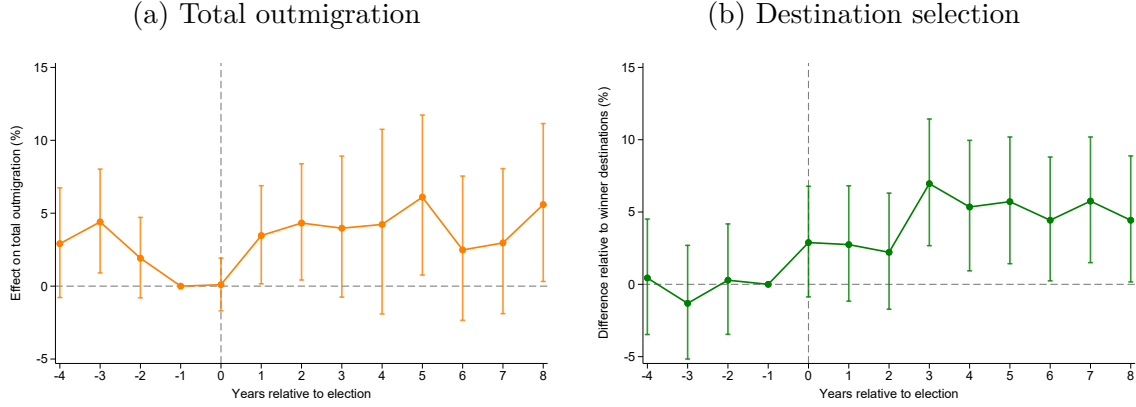
$$\mathbb{E}[Y_{oet} \mid X] = \exp \left[\alpha_{oe} + \lambda_{et} + \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k (\mathbf{1}\{t - t_e = k\} \times T_{oe}) \right]. \quad (1)$$

Here, Y_{oet} is total interstate outmigration from origin county o in calendar year t and election stack e . The treatment indicator T_{oe} equals one when the origin county supported the losing gubernatorial candidate. Origin-county–election fixed effects α_{oe} absorb time-invariant differences across counties within each stack, while election–year fixed effects λ_{et} absorb shocks common to all counties in an election stack and calendar year. The coefficients β_k compare the change in outmigration from losing counties with the contemporaneous change from winner counties at event time k , relative to year $k = -1$.

Destination selection. For the composition margin, we estimate

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[Y_{odet} \mid X] = \exp & \left[\alpha_{oet} + \delta_{det} + \mu_{ode} \right. \\ & \left. + \sum_{k \neq -1} \sum_{g \in \{L, S\}} \beta_k^g (\mathbf{1}\{t - t_e = k\} \times T_{oe} \times G_{de}^g) \right]. \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

Figure 4: Migration responses to a close electoral loss



Notes: Dynamic PPML estimates expressed as percentage effects. Event year -1 is omitted and bars show 95 percent confidence intervals. Panel (a) compares total interstate outmigration from losing and winning counties. Panel (b) is the loser-party–winner-party destination contrast and holds total origin outmigration and contemporaneous destination-specific shocks fixed.

Here, Y_{odet} is the flow from origin county o to destination county d . The indicators G_{de}^g classify destinations as loser-party strongholds ($g = L$) or swing states ($g = S$); winner-party strongholds are omitted. Origin–year–election fixed effects α_{oet} hold total origin outmigration fixed, destination–year–election fixed effects δ_{det} absorb contemporaneous destination shocks, and origin–destination–election fixed effects μ_{ode} absorb persistent bilateral migration patterns. Each β_k^g is the change in migration from losing counties toward destination type g , relative to winner-party destinations and event year -1 .

For both specifications, joint Wald tests assess the pre-election path from event years -4 through -2 and the post-election paths over years $0-4$ and $0-8$. We also report equally weighted averages of the event-time coefficients over these periods. Leave-one-out exercises show how the estimates change when individual elections, states, or election years are removed.

3.2 Baseline evidence

Figure 4 presents the baseline results. Panel (a) reports total outmigration from losing relative to winning counties. Panel (b) reports the loser-party–winner-party destination contrast, conditional on total outmigration from each origin.

Total outmigration rises gradually after the election and remains elevated. The

Table 2: Robustness of total outmigration and the loser–winner destination contrast

Specification	Elections	Total outmigration				Loser–winner destinations			
		Obs.	Effect	Pre p	Post p	Obs.	Effect	Pre p	Post p
Baseline: 5 pp, individuals	45	20,839	3.21%	0.069	0.255	497,333	4.02%	0.783	0.032
2.5 pp, individuals	21	9,763	3.54%	0.611	0.007	245,119	0.86%	0.024	0.838
5 pp, households	45	20,839	3.63%	0.043	0.195	497,333	3.64%	0.536	0.022
Predetermined strongholds	45	–	–	–	–	497,333	1.78%	0.412	0.499

Notes: Effects are average percentage effects over event years zero through four. Pre p jointly tests event years $-4, -3, -2$; post p jointly tests years $0, \dots, 4$. Winner-party strongholds are the omitted destination category. Dashes indicate that the predetermined-strongholds specification changes only destination classification and therefore does not alter total outmigration.

average effect is 3.21 percent over years 0–4 and 3.68 percent over years 0–8. The corresponding average-effect p -values are 0.072 and 0.068; the joint-path p -values are 0.255 and below 0.001. The delayed response is consistent with policies taking effect after inauguration and with the time required to arrange a move.

Destination composition changes in the same political direction. The loser-party–winner-party contrast averages 4.02 percent over years 0–4 and 4.49 percent over years 0–8. Over the first five years, the average-effect and joint-path p -values are 0.015 and 0.032. Because origin–year–election fixed effects hold total outmigration fixed, this estimate is not a mechanical consequence of additional departures. Political shocks change where migrants go, not only how many leave.

3.3 Validation and robustness

Pre-election dynamics differ across the two outcomes. For total outmigration, the pre-period average and joint-path p -values are 0.040 and 0.069. For destination selection, they are 0.878 and 0.783. The volume result therefore warrants more caution. Table 2 shows that the main patterns are not specific to one migration unit or election cutoff, although magnitudes and precision vary.

Every leave-one-election-out estimate for total outmigration is positive, although California 2002 has substantial influence on its magnitude. The destination contrast is tightly concentrated around the full-sample estimate and remains positive and significant in all 45 samples. Thus, destination selection has the cleaner validation profile; the volume response is positive across the main variants but less stable in its inference.

3.4 Heterogeneity and mechanism evidence

We next ask whether migration responds more strongly when candidates offer more distinct ideological alternatives. Section 4 formalizes this comparative static in the migration-selection model.

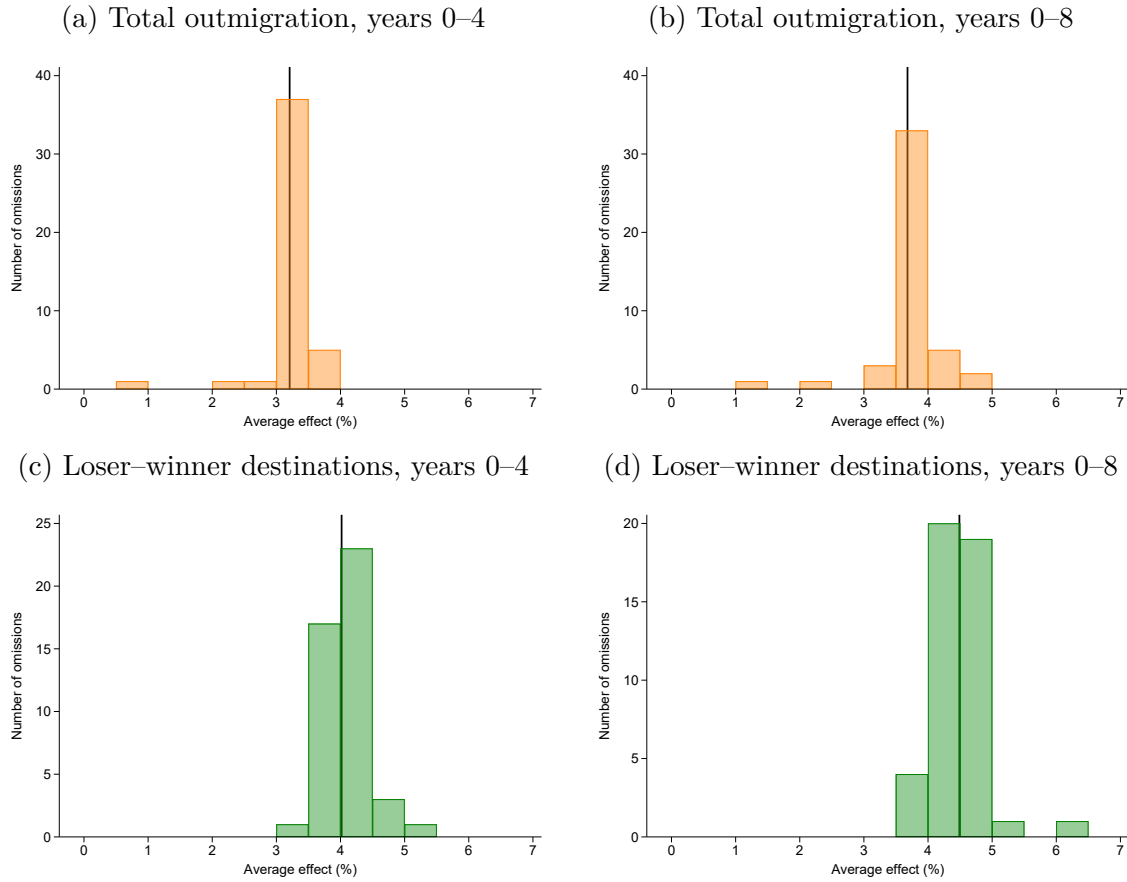
Candidate ideological distance The DIME data cover both nominees in 32 baseline elections. We interact the event-study path with indicators for candidate distance below and at or above the covered-sample median. Estimating both paths jointly permits direct tests of the large-minus-small difference.

Panel (a) of Figure 6 shows pronounced heterogeneity in total outmigration. Over years 0–4, the average effect is 8.89 percent in large-gap elections ($p = 0.050$) and -1.42 percent in small-gap elections ($p = 0.349$). The 10.46 percentage-point difference has a p -value of 0.031, and equality of the post-election paths is rejected ($p = 0.001$). This concentration is consistent with a larger political shock moving more residents on the losing side across their migration threshold.

The heterogeneity is not an independently identified effect of candidate polarization. The average large-minus-small difference over years -4 to -2 is 0.49 percent ($p = 0.887$), but equality of the three pre-election coefficients is rejected ($p = 0.034$). Moreover, ideology scores are unavailable for 13 baseline elections. We therefore interpret the estimates as supportive, but suggestive, mechanism evidence.

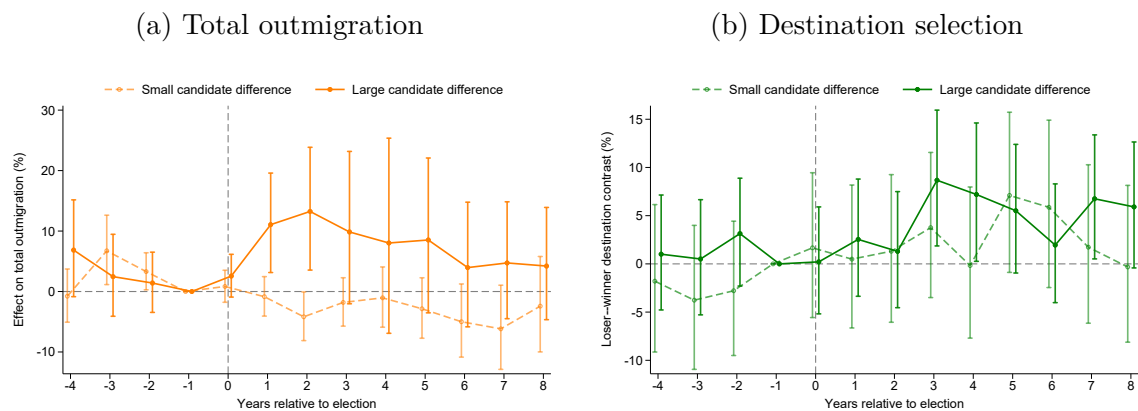
Panel (b) is directionally similar but imprecise. The loser–winner destination contrast averages 3.93 percent after large-gap elections and 1.40 percent after small-gap elections. Their 2.49 percentage-point difference has a p -value of 0.530, and equality of the post-election paths cannot be rejected ($p = 0.578$). Candidate distance therefore predicts the decision to leave more clearly than the political direction of destination choice.

Figure 5: Distribution of leave-one-election-out estimates



Notes: Each panel summarizes the 45 estimates obtained by omitting one election at a time. The vertical black line is the corresponding full-sample estimate. These histograms describe sensitivity to individual elections; because the leave-one-out estimates are highly correlated, they are not sampling distributions and should not be used for statistical inference. Election-labelled influence plots are reported in Figures A.5 and A.6.

Figure 6: Migration responses by the ideological difference between candidates



Notes: Dynamic PPML estimates for 32 close elections with DIME scores for both major-party nominees. A large candidate difference is an absolute composite-score distance at or above the covered-sample median of 4.506; each group contains 16 elections. Event year -1 is omitted. Bars show 95 percent confidence intervals. Panel (a) shows the effect on total outmigration. Panel (b) compares loser-party with winner-party stronghold destinations.

4 Migration selection and political distance

The event studies show that more residents leave losing counties for out-of-state destinations and that migration shifts toward places aligned with the losing party. This section links both findings in a migration-selection model. Section 4.2 then examines the model’s political-matching prediction in the national state-to-state migration network.

4.1 Migration-selection framework

Political preferences and location-specific utility. Consider an origin state o with a locally winning county W , a locally losing county L , and a potential destination state d . Individual political orientation is $\nu_i \in [-1, 1]$, with negative values denoting relatively liberal preferences and positive values relatively conservative preferences. Let $F_c(\nu)$ be the distribution in county $c \in \{L, W\}$. The counties have different preference distributions but face the same state policy.

Individual i ’s utility in location $r \in \{o, d\}$ is

$$u_{ir} = a_r + q_r \nu_i, \quad (3)$$

where a_r collects wages, housing costs, public services, social networks, and other nonpolitical amenities, and q_r is state-policy orientation. The interaction $q_r \nu_i$ is a political-match premium: utility is higher when individual preferences and state policy are more closely aligned. This formulation applies Roy–Borjas selection logic to heterogeneous returns to political preferences (Borjas 1987; Borjas 2014).

Political orientation is fixed during the migration decision. This short-run assumption allows places to affect later political behavior; it requires only that the preferences inducing a move do not change instantaneously.

An individual moves from o to d when

$$a_d - k_{od} + q_d \nu_i \geq a_o + q_o \nu_i, \quad (4)$$

where k_{od} denotes monetary, informational, social, and psychological moving costs. If $q_d < q_o$, so that the destination is more liberal than the origin, the indifferent

individual has orientation

$$\nu_{od}^* = \frac{a_o + k_{od} - a_d}{q_d - q_o}, \quad (5)$$

and individuals with $\nu_i \leq \nu_{od}^*$ choose the destination. Political disagreement generates migration only when the gain in political match compensates for foregone amenities and moving costs.

Prediction 1: electoral losses increase outmigration. Suppose a close election moves origin policy from q_o to a more conservative $q'_o > q_o$. For a liberal destination $q_d < q_o$, and provided the origin's amenity advantage plus moving costs is positive, Equation (5) implies $\nu_{od}^{*'} > \nu_{od}^*$. The share moving from county c consequently changes by

$$\Delta M_{cd} = F_c(\nu_{od}^{*'}) - F_c(\nu_{od}^*). \quad (6)$$

Both counties may experience greater outmigration because they face the same state policy. The empirical prediction concerns their relative responses. If the losing county contains more residents over the interval between the two cutoffs, then $\Delta M_{Ld} > \Delta M_{Wd}$. Following a liberal policy shift, the symmetric argument applies to conservative residents in counties that supported the Republican loser.

A larger policy shift moves the cutoff in Equation (5) farther and brings more mismatched residents above the migration threshold. Candidate distance is an imperfect proxy for this change, but the larger outmigration response in ideologically distant races is consistent with the comparative static in Section 3.4.

County returns reveal differences in preference distributions, not the views of each resident. The treatment therefore does not require every resident of a losing county to oppose the winner. The estimate is an average response to compositional differences across counties.

The model also accommodates gradual adjustment. Policies may become known or take effect after inauguration, and households may need time to find work and housing or unwind local commitments. Delayed responses can therefore reflect policy implementation and moving frictions rather than an immediate expressive reaction. Effective moving costs also generate heterogeneity across education, occupation, and homeownership.

Prediction 2: migrants select politically aligned destinations. The same policy shift predicts destination choice. Among locations with similar amenities and moving costs, liberal individuals prefer lower q_d and conservative individuals prefer higher q_d . Residents induced to leave should therefore disproportionately choose destinations governed by, or electorally aligned with, the party they supported. The prediction is symmetric across Democratic and Republican victories.

This prediction corresponds to Equation (2). Departures and destination composition need not move one-for-one: an election may both induce new moves and redirect moves that would have occurred anyway. Total departures may also rise with little reallocation when employment, family ties, or housing costs dominate political fit.

Party labels divide locations into broad groups, but political fit is continuous. Holding amenities and moving costs fixed, the model predicts larger flows between politically closer states. Section 4.2 examines this implication in a state-to-state gravity model.

4.2 Gravity evidence

The close-election design provides the main empirical evidence. We now ask whether the model’s political-matching prediction also appears in the national state-to-state migration network. This exercise uses observational variation and provides corroborating evidence, not a second causal design.

We use the Manifesto Project right–left scores for Democratic and Republican presidential candidates (Lehmann et al. 2023). For state s in presidential election year t , political orientation is the vote-share-weighted candidate position, $polor_{st} = \sum_j voteshare_{jst} rle_{jt}$, and bilateral political distance is

$$poldist_{odt} = |polor_{ot} - polor_{dt}|. \quad (7)$$

The measure is continuous and varies within as well as across conventional red-state–blue-state groups. Appendix Figure A.8 documents its construction; Appendix Figure A.9 shows the unconditional relationship with migration.

We aggregate IRS flows to ordered state pairs for the eight presidential elections from 1992 through 2020 and use migration in the following year. We estimate by PPML

$$\mathbb{E}[M_{od,t+1} \mid X] = \exp[\beta poldist_{odt} + \boldsymbol{\gamma}' \mathbf{X}_{od} + \pi_{ot} + \pi_{dt}], \quad (8)$$

where $\mathbf{X}_{od}$ contains log distance between state capitals and contiguity. Some specifications also indicate whether the same presidential candidate won both states. Origin–year and destination–year fixed effects absorb time-varying push and pull factors and provide the multilateral-resistance structure implied by random-utility migration models (Ortega and Peri 2013; Bertoli and Fernández-Huertas Moraga 2015). Standard errors are clustered by state pair.

Table 3 reports the results. Migration falls with geographic distance and rises between contiguous states. In Column (2), political distance has a coefficient of -2.177 , significant at the 1 percent level. Column (3) shows that states won by the same presidential candidate exchange more migrants. When both measures enter in Column (4), political distance remains negative and significant, while the same-winner coefficient becomes small and insignificant. Political distance therefore contains information within broad partisan groups.

The association survives controls for historical state alignment and coastal-state

Table 3: Migration and political distance

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Log distance	−0.759*** (0.025)	−0.746*** (0.025)	−0.753*** (0.025)	−0.746*** (0.025)
Contiguity	0.690*** (0.052)	0.691*** (0.051)	0.691*** (0.052)	0.691*** (0.051)
Political Distance		−2.177*** (0.501)		−2.205*** (0.497)
Winner-Pair			0.050*** (0.019)	−0.002 (0.017)
Observations	19600	19600	19600	19600
Origin-Time FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Destination-Time FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: The dependent variable is the bilateral flow of individuals in the year after a presidential election. All specifications are estimated by PPML. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by state pair. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

pairs, although the latter attenuate its magnitude (Appendix Table A.12). These controls cannot eliminate persistent ties or time-varying pair-specific confounds. The gravity result therefore shows consistency with the broader geography of migration, not a causal effect of political distance.

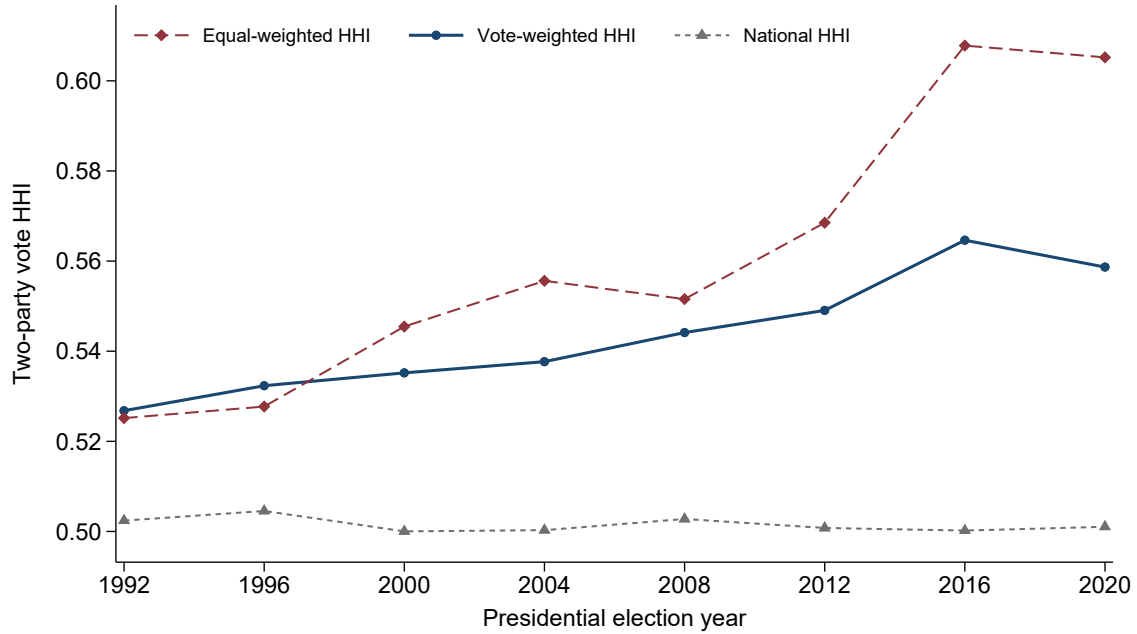
4.3 Implications for geographic polarization

Politically selective migration may change both sides of a flow. If residents who disagree with the origin government leave, the remaining population becomes relatively more aligned with it. If those movers choose aligned destinations, destination populations may also become more concentrated in their prevailing direction. Repeated shocks could therefore widen political differences across places.

Figure 7 provides descriptive context. The geographic concentration of two-party presidential voting increased between 1992 and 2020 whether counties are weighted equally or by their number of votes, while the national HHI remained close to its minimum. This pattern is consistent with greater geographic sorting rather than a

growing nationwide imbalance between the two parties, but it does not identify its cause. Party switching, generational replacement, turnout, and contextual effects also change county vote shares (Brown, Cantoni, et al. 2025; Martin and Webster 2020). Our event study identifies migration in a sorting direction; it does not quantify how much of the aggregate trend those flows explain.

Figure 7: Geographic concentration in U.S. presidential voting



Notes: For each presidential election from 1992 through 2020, a county's two-party Herfindahl-Hirschman index (HHI) is the sum of the squared Democratic and Republican vote shares. These values are then aggregated to the country level using equal weights or total two-party votes as weights. The national series applies the same calculation to aggregate U.S. vote shares. Authors' calculations from county presidential-election returns (Algara and Amlani 2021).

5 Conclusion

This paper shows that political shocks affect both whether and where people move within the United States. We combine county-to-county IRS migration flows with 45 close gubernatorial elections in a stacked event study. Total outmigration from losing counties rises by 3.21 percent over the first five post-election years and by 3.68 percent over the first nine. Conditional on total departures and destination shocks, migration toward loser-party strongholds rises by 4.02 percent relative to migration toward winner-party strongholds over the first five years. The volume response is less precisely estimated and more sensitive to particular elections; the destination response has the cleaner pre-election and leave-one-out validation profile.

Candidate ideology and the migration-selection model help interpret these findings. The outmigration response is concentrated in elections with larger ideological differences between candidates, consistent with larger political shocks moving more mismatched residents across the migration threshold. The model links this departure margin to destination choice: conditional on moving, politically responsive residents prefer better-matched locations. A supplementary gravity exercise finds that politically distant states exchange fewer migrants. The ideology and gravity results support the political-matching mechanism but do not provide separate causal designs.

These responses operate in the direction of greater geographic sorting. More residents leave locally losing counties, and their migration shifts toward destinations aligned with the losing party. The estimates establish this direction, not its aggregate historical importance. They do not quantify permanent changes in population stocks, subsequent voting, or the contribution of election-induced migration to geographic polarization. Such a calculation would require a dynamic counterfactual that accumulates moves, allows for return and onward migration, and links migration to later political behavior.

More broadly, the results add political conditions to the location attributes that shape internal migration. Elections determine not only who governs a place but also its relative appeal to residents and potential movers. This creates a connection between political institutions and economic geography: political outcomes affect where people live, while selective mobility may in turn alter the environments in which future political and economic decisions are made.

References

- Algara, Carlos and Sharif Amlani (2021). “Replication Data for: Partisanship & Nationalization in American Elections: Evidence from Presidential, Senatorial, & Gubernatorial Elections in the U.S. Counties, 1872-2020”. Version V1.
- Banzhaf, H. Spencer and Randall P. Walsh (2008). “Do People Vote with Their Feet? An Empirical Test of Tiebout”. *American Economic Review*, 98(3): 843–63.
- Beland, Louis-Philippe (2015). “Political Parties and Labor-Market Outcomes: Evidence from US States”. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 7(4): 198–220.
- Bertoli, Simone and Jesús Fernández-Huertas Moraga (2015). “The Size of the Cliff at the Border”. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, 51: 1–6.
- Besley, Timothy and Anne Case (1995). “Does Electoral Accountability Affect Economic Policy Choices? Evidence from Gubernatorial Term Limits”. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 110(3): 769–798.
- Bonica, Adam (2014). “Mapping the Ideological Marketplace”. *American Journal of Political Science*, 58(2): 367–386.
- Borjas, George J. (1987). “Self-Selection and the Earnings of Immigrants”. *American Economic Review*, 77(4): 531–553.
- (2014). *Immigration economics*. Harvard University Press.
- Brown, Jacob R., Enrico Cantoni, Ryan D. Enos, Vincent Pons, and Emilie Sartre (2025). *Sources and Extent of Rising Partisan Segregation in the U.S.: Evidence from 143 Million Voters*. Working Paper 33422. Revised February 2026. National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Brown, Jacob R. and Ryan D. Enos (2021). “The Measurement of Partisan Sorting for 180 Million Voters”. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 5: 998–1008.
- Correia, Sergio, Paulo Guimarães, and Tom Zylkin (2020). “Fast Poisson estimation with high-dimensional fixed effects”. *The Stata Journal*, 20(1): 95–115.
- DeWaard, Jacob et al. (2021). “User Beware: Concerning Findings from the Post 2011–2012 U.S. Internal Revenue Service Migration Data”. *Population Research and Policy Review*, 41: 437–448.
- Diamond, Rebecca (2016). “The Determinants and Welfare Implications of US Workers’ Diverging Location Choices by Skill: 1980–2000”. *American Economic Review*, 106(3): 479–524.

- Downey, Mitch and Jinci Liu (2026). “Political Preferences and Migration Decisions of College-Educated Workers”. Working paper, resubmitted to American Economic Journal: Applied Economics.
- Efthymoulou, Georgios, Vincenzo Bove, and Harry Pickard (2023). “Micromotives and Macromoves: Political Preferences and Internal Migration in England and Wales”. *Journal of Economic Geography*, 23(5): 1145–1167.
- Fiva, Jon H. (2009). “Does Welfare Policy Affect Residential Choices? An Empirical Investigation Accounting for Policy Endogeneity”. *Journal of Public Economics*, 93(3–4): 529–540.
- Hauer, Mathew and James Byars (2019). “IRS county-to-county migration data, 1990–2010”. *Demographic Research*, 40: 1153–1166.
- Huijsmans, Twan and Jonathan Rodden (2025). “The Great Global Divider? A Comparison of Urban–Rural Partisan Polarization in Western Democracies”. *Comparative Political Studies*, 58(2): 261–290.
- Internal Revenue Service (2026). *SOI Tax Stats – Migration Data*. <https://www.irs.gov/statistics/soi-tax-stats-migration-data>. Statistics of Income data. Accessed May 24, 2026.
- Jia, Ning, Raven Molloy, Christopher Smith, and Abigail Wozniak (2023). “The Economics of Internal Migration: Advances and Policy Questions”. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 61(1): 144–80.
- Kaplan, Ethan, Jörg L. Spenkuch, and Rebecca Sullivan (2022). “Partisan spatial sorting in the United States: A theoretical and empirical overview”. *Journal of Public Economics*, 211: 104668.
- Lee, David S., Enrico Moretti, and Matthew J. Butler (2004). “Do Voters Affect or Elect Policies? Evidence from the U.S. House”. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 119(3): 807–859.
- Lehmann, Pola et al. (2023). *The Manifesto Data Collection. Manifesto Project (MRG/CMP/MARPOR). Version 2023a*. Berlin: Wissenschaftszentrum Berlin für Sozialforschung (WZB)/ Göttingen: Institut für Demokratieforschung (IfDem).
- Martin, Gregory J. and Steven W. Webster (2020). “Does Residential Sorting Explain Geographic Polarization?” *Political Science Research and Methods*, 8(2): 215–231.
- Moretti, Enrico and Daniel J. Wilson (2017). “The Effect of State Taxes on the Geographical Location of Top Earners: Evidence from Star Scientists”. *American Economic Review*, 107(7): 1858–1903.

- Mummolo, Jonathan and Clayton Nall (2017). “Why Partisans Do Not Sort: The Constraints on Political Segregation”. *The Journal of Politics*, 79(1): 45–59.
- Ortega, Francesc and Giovanni Peri (2013). “The effect of income and immigration policies on international migration”. *Migration Studies*, 1(1): 47–74.
- Pickard, Harry, Vincenzo Bove, and Georgios Efthymoulou (2022). “You (Br)exit, I Stay: The Effect of the Brexit Vote on Internal Migration”. *Political Geography*, 95: 102576.
- Silva, João Santos and Silvana Tenreyro (2006). “The log of gravity”. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, 88(4): 641–658.
- Tam Cho, Wendy K., James G. Gimpel, and Iris S. Hui (2013). “Voter Migration and the Geographic Sorting of the American Electorate”. *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, 103(4): 856–870.
- Tiebout, Charles M. (1956). “A Pure Theory of Local Expenditures”. *Journal of Political Economy*, 64(5): 416–424.

Appendix

A.1 Baseline election sample

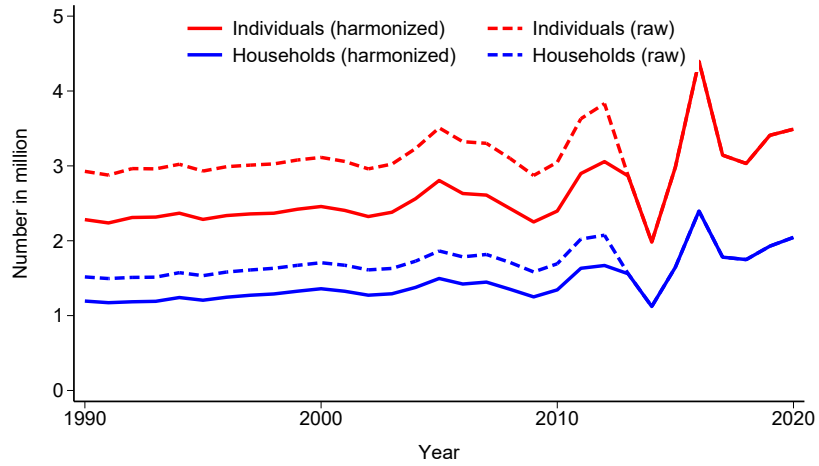
Table A.1: Gubernatorial elections in the baseline sample

State	Year	Midterm	Winner	Total votes	Winning margin	Treated counties	Control counties
AL	1994	Yes	R	1,201,969	0.9 pp	34	22
FL	1994	Yes	D	4,206,659	1.5 pp	38	19
GA	1994	Yes	D	1,545,328	2.1 pp	58	44
NY	1994	Yes	R	5,208,762	3.3 pp	5	53
SC	1994	Yes	R	933,850	2.5 pp	23	22
KY	1995	No	D	983,979	2.2 pp	32	39
IN	1996	No	D	2,110,047	4.7 pp	39	39
NJ	1997	No	R	2,418,344	1.1 pp	10	11
CO	1998	Yes	R	1,321,307	0.6 pp	14	28
IL	1998	Yes	R	3,358,705	3.6 pp	34	45
MA	1998	Yes	R	1,903,336	3.4 pp	5	9
MS	1999	No	D	763,938	1.1 pp	28	39
MO	2000	No	D	2,346,830	0.9 pp	49	27
MT	2000	No	R	410,192	3.9 pp	8	15
WV	2000	No	D	648,047	2.9 pp	21	20
AL	2002	Yes	R	1,367,053	0.2 pp	25	31
AZ	2002	Yes	D	1,226,111	1.0 pp	7	8
CA	2002	Yes	D	7,476,311	4.9 pp	37	18
MA	2002	Yes	R	2,194,179	4.8 pp	6	8
MI	2002	Yes	D	3,177,565	4.0 pp	45	19
OK	2002	Yes	D	1,035,620	0.7 pp	19	38
OR	2002	Yes	D	1,260,497	2.9 pp	23	8
TN	2002	Yes	D	1,653,167	3.1 pp	32	32
WI	2002	Yes	D	1,775,349	3.7 pp	27	39
WY	2002	Yes	D	185,459	2.0 pp	14	7
MT	2004	No	D	446,146	4.4 pp	10	13
WA	2004	No	D	2,810,058	0.0 pp	27	8
MN	2006	Yes	R	2,202,937	1.0 pp	28	52
NC	2008	No	D	4,268,941	3.4 pp	35	52
NJ	2009	No	R	2,423,792	3.6 pp	8	13
FL	2010	Yes	R	5,359,735	1.1 pp	13	44
MN	2010	Yes	D	2,107,021	0.4 pp	56	24
OH	2010	Yes	R	3,852,469	2.0 pp	21	52
OR	2010	Yes	D	1,453,548	1.5 pp	24	7
SC	2010	Yes	R	1,344,198	4.5 pp	24	21
IN	2012	No	R	2,577,329	2.9 pp	17	61
MT	2012	No	D	483,489	1.6 pp	13	10
WA	2012	No	D	3,071,047	3.1 pp	27	8
WV	2012	No	D	664,455	4.8 pp	14	27
VA	2013	No	D	2,241,071	2.5 pp	57	36
CO	2014	Yes	D	2,041,607	3.3 pp	25	18
FL	2014	Yes	R	5,951,561	1.1 pp	13	44
KS	2014	Yes	R	869,502	3.7 pp	7	39
MA	2014	Yes	R	2,158,326	1.9 pp	7	7
MI	2014	Yes	R	3,156,531	4.1 pp	11	53
Sum				100,196,367		1,070	1,229

Notes: The table lists the 45 close gubernatorial elections in the baseline estimation sample. Total votes include third-party votes. The winning margin is the absolute Democratic–Republican vote-share difference in percentage points, using total votes as the denominator. Treated counties supported the losing major-party candidate; control counties supported the winner. County counts refer to origin counties in the estimation stack. The final row sums total votes and county counts.

A.2 Aggregate interstate migration

Figure A.1: Interstate migration in the IRS data



Notes: Annual interstate migration measured by individuals and households. The harmonized series applies a minimum cell size of 20 returns throughout the sample.

A.3 Total outmigration

Table A.2: Event-study estimates for total outmigration

Event year	Coefficient	Standard error	<i>p</i> -value
−4	0.0287	0.0187	0.124
−3	0.0431**	0.0174	0.013
−2	0.0190	0.0138	0.168
−1	Omitted category		
0	0.0010	0.0092	0.916
1	0.0341**	0.0166	0.040
2	0.0424**	0.0195	0.030
3	0.0390	0.0237	0.101
4	0.0414	0.0310	0.181
5	0.0592**	0.0264	0.025
6	0.0245	0.0246	0.319
7	0.0292	0.0246	0.236
8	0.0544**	0.0261	0.037
Observations			20,839
Elections			45
Origin county × election FE			Yes
Election × year FE			Yes

Notes: The table reports the PPML coefficients underlying Figure 4a. The dependent variable is total interstate outmigration from an origin county. Treatment is an origin-county plurality for the losing gubernatorial candidate. Standard errors are clustered by origin county–election. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.3: Total-outmigration estimates

Period	Average log effect	Percent effect	Average p	Joint-path p
Pre-treatment, -4 to -2	0.0303	3.07	0.040	0.069
Post-election, 0 to 4	0.0316	3.21	0.072	0.255
Post-election, 0 to 8	0.0361	3.68	0.068	< 0.001

Notes: The average is the equally weighted mean of the event-time coefficients in the stated period. Percent effects are $100[\exp(\bar{\beta}) - 1]$. Joint-path tests set all coefficients in the period to zero. The baseline includes 45 elections and 20,839 origin-county-year-election observations.

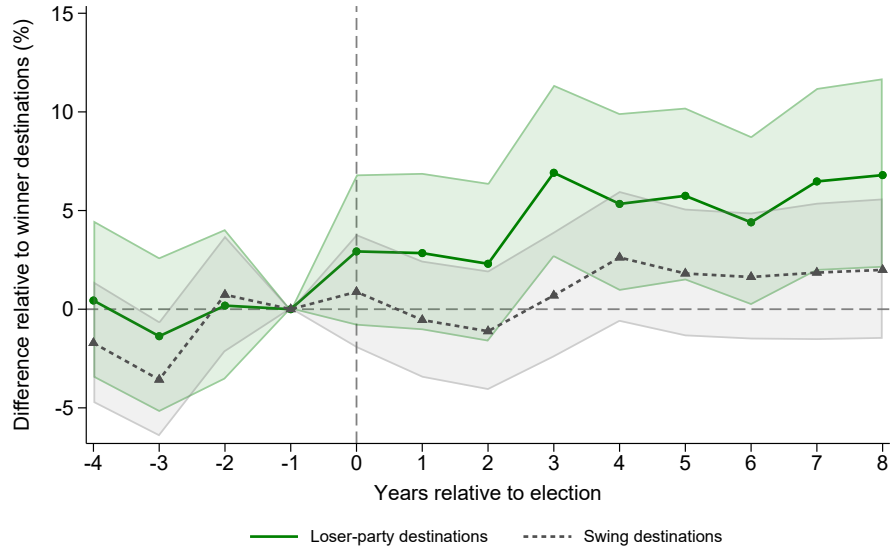
A.4 Destination composition

Table A.4: Event-study estimates for destination composition

Event year	Loser-party destinations		Swing destinations	
	Coefficient	Standard error	Coefficient	Standard error
−4	0.0044	0.0203	−0.0165	0.0161
−3	−0.0132	0.0203	−0.0348**	0.0155
−2	0.0029	0.0194	0.0090	0.0150
−1	Omitted category			
0	0.0285	0.0190	0.0089	0.0146
1	0.0271	0.0198	−0.0059	0.0153
2	0.0219	0.0200	−0.0114	0.0157
3	0.0673***	0.0209	0.0073	0.0162
4	0.0521**	0.0218	0.0261	0.0165
5	0.0556***	0.0211	0.0183	0.0163
6	0.0434**	0.0209	0.0159	0.0162
7	0.0560***	0.0210	0.0203	0.0166
8	0.0434**	0.0213	0.0130	0.0169
Observations				497,333
Elections				45
Origin × year × election FE				Yes
Destination × year × election FE				Yes
Origin × destination × election FE				Yes

Notes: The table reports the PPML coefficients underlying Figure 4b. Winner-party strongholds are the omitted destination category; Figure 4b displays the loser-party contrast. Treatment is an origin-county plurality for the losing gubernatorial candidate. Standard errors are clustered by origin–destination–election. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure A.2: Destination composition including swing destinations



Notes: Dynamic PPML contrasts with winner-party strongholds as the omitted destination category. The figure shows both loser-party and swing destinations. The omitted event year is -1 ; shaded areas show 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table A.5: Magnitude of destination reallocation

Horizon	Elections	Reallocated person-moves	Mean per election	Observed-flow share
0–4	45	34,527	767	0.51%
0–8	45	65,057	1,446	0.54%

Table A.6: Full destination-composition contrasts

Contrast	Period	Percent effect	Average p	Joint-path p
Loser – winner	Pre, –4 to –2	–0.20	0.905	0.783
Swing – winner	Pre, –4 to –2	–1.40	0.272	0.022
Loser – winner	Post, 0 to 4	4.02	0.015	0.032
Swing – winner	Post, 0 to 4	0.50	0.689	0.196
Loser – winner	Post, 0 to 8	4.49	0.007	0.105
Swing – winner	Post, 0 to 8	1.03	0.414	0.404

Notes: Winner-party strongholds are omitted. Average effects are converted using $100[\exp(\bar{\beta}) - 1]$. Joint-path tests set all coefficients in the stated period to zero.

A.5 Candidate ideological distance

Tables A.7 and A.8 report the ideology heterogeneity underlying Figure 6. Column (1) gives the baseline estimate, Column (2) restricts the sample to 32 elections with scores for both nominees, and Columns (3) and (4) split this sample at the median candidate distance. The two group-specific paths are estimated jointly.

Table A.7: Total outmigration and candidate ideological distance

	Baseline (1)	DIME covered (2)	Small difference (3)	Large difference (4)
<i>Treatment</i> $\times$ <i>year</i>				
−4	0.029 (0.019)	0.034 (0.023)	−0.008 (0.023)	0.066* (0.038)
−3	0.043** (0.017)	0.044* (0.023)	0.065** (0.027)	0.024 (0.034)
−2	0.019 (0.014)	0.024 (0.016)	0.033** (0.015)	0.014 (0.025)
−1	Omitted category			
0	0.001 (0.009)	0.016 (0.011)	0.008 (0.013)	0.025 (0.018)
1	0.034** (0.017)	0.056** (0.022)	−0.009 (0.017)	0.105*** (0.038)
2	0.042** (0.020)	0.050* (0.027)	−0.043** (0.021)	0.124*** (0.046)
3	0.039 (0.024)	0.046 (0.033)	−0.018 (0.021)	0.094 (0.058)
4	0.041 (0.031)	0.039 (0.044)	−0.011 (0.026)	0.077 (0.076)
5	0.059** (0.026)	0.033 (0.034)	−0.029 (0.026)	0.082 (0.060)
6	0.025 (0.025)	−0.001 (0.031)	−0.051 (0.033)	0.039 (0.051)
7	0.029 (0.025)	−0.002 (0.031)	−0.064* (0.038)	0.046 (0.047)
8	0.054** (0.026)	0.012 (0.031)	−0.025 (0.041)	0.041 (0.045)
Observations	20,839	14,430	14,430	14,430
Elections	45	32	16	16
<i>p</i> : average effect, years 0–4	0.072	0.090	0.349	0.050
<i>p</i> : joint pretrend, years −4–−2	0.069	0.268	0.113	0.093
<i>p</i> : joint post path, years 0–4	0.255	0.135	0.136	0.008

Notes: The dependent variable is total interstate outmigration from an origin county. Treatment is an origin-county plurality for the losing gubernatorial candidate. Column (1) uses all 45 baseline elections. Column (2) restricts the sample to the 32 elections covered by DIME. Columns (3) and (4) split those elections at the covered-sample median absolute candidate difference of 4.506; both paths are estimated jointly in one interacted regression. All models include origin-county–election and election–year fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by origin county–election. The average-effect test concerns the equally weighted mean of the five coefficients for years 0–4; the path tests jointly set the indicated coefficients to zero. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

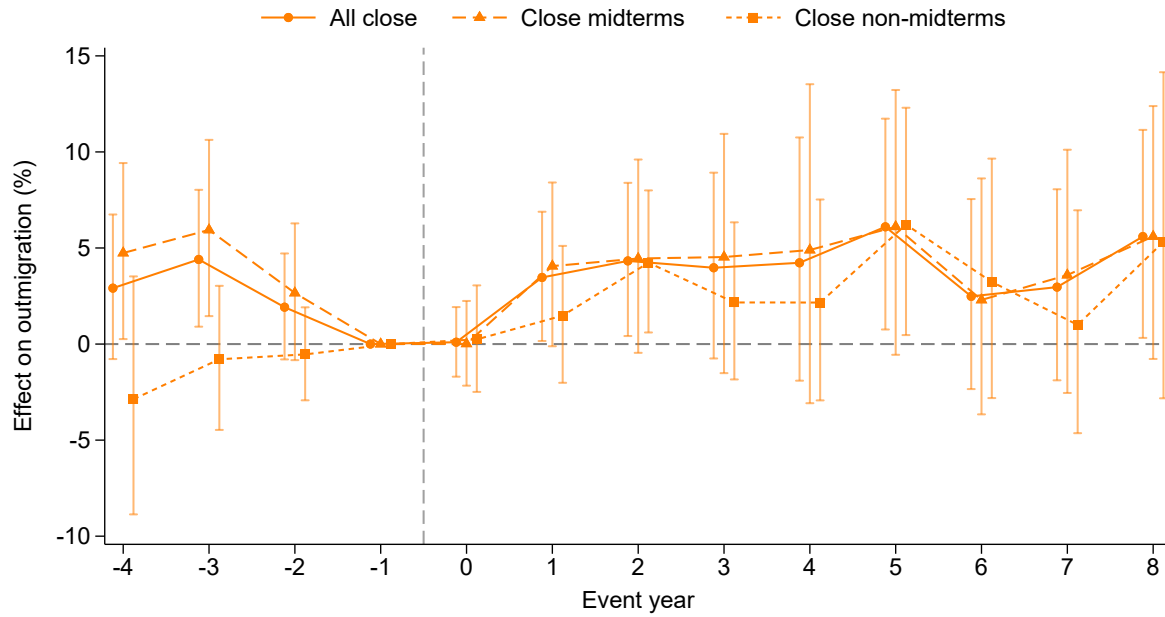
Table A.8: Destination selection and candidate ideological distance

	Baseline (1)	DIME covered (2)	Small difference (3)	Large difference (4)
<i>Treatment × year</i>				
−4	0.004 (0.020)	0.006 (0.024)	−0.018 (0.040)	0.010 (0.030)
−3	−0.013 (0.020)	−0.007 (0.024)	−0.038 (0.040)	0.005 (0.030)
−2	0.003 (0.019)	0.011 (0.022)	−0.028 (0.037)	0.031 (0.028)
−1	Omitted category			
0	0.029 (0.019)	0.014 (0.022)	0.017 (0.038)	0.002 (0.028)
1	0.027 (0.020)	0.026 (0.024)	0.005 (0.038)	0.025 (0.030)
2	0.022 (0.020)	0.015 (0.024)	0.013 (0.039)	0.013 (0.030)
3	0.067*** (0.021)	0.069*** (0.025)	0.037 (0.037)	0.083** (0.033)
4	0.052** (0.022)	0.047* (0.026)	−0.002 (0.040)	0.070** (0.034)
5	0.056*** (0.021)	0.061** (0.025)	0.069* (0.040)	0.054* (0.032)
6	0.043** (0.021)	0.036 (0.025)	0.057 (0.042)	0.019 (0.031)
7	0.056*** (0.021)	0.051** (0.025)	0.017 (0.041)	0.065** (0.031)
8	0.043** (0.021)	0.038 (0.025)	−0.003 (0.042)	0.057* (0.031)
Observations	497,333	338,937	338,937	338,937
Elections	45	32	16	16
<i>p</i> : average effect, years 0–4	0.015	0.075	0.648	0.118
<i>p</i> : joint pretrend, years −4–−2	0.783	0.857	0.794	0.683
<i>p</i> : joint post path, years 0–4	0.032	0.086	0.861	0.094

Notes: The dependent variable is the bilateral migration flow. Coefficients report the loser-party minus winner-party destination contrast for treated origin counties; winner-party destinations are the omitted category. Column (1) uses all 45 baseline elections. Column (2) restricts the sample to the 32 elections covered by DIME. Columns (3) and (4) split those elections at the covered-sample median absolute candidate difference of 4.506; both paths are estimated jointly in one interacted regression. All models include origin–year–election, destination–year–election, and origin–destination–election fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by origin–destination–election. The average-effect test concerns the equally weighted mean of the five coefficients for years 0–4; the path tests jointly set the indicated coefficients to zero. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

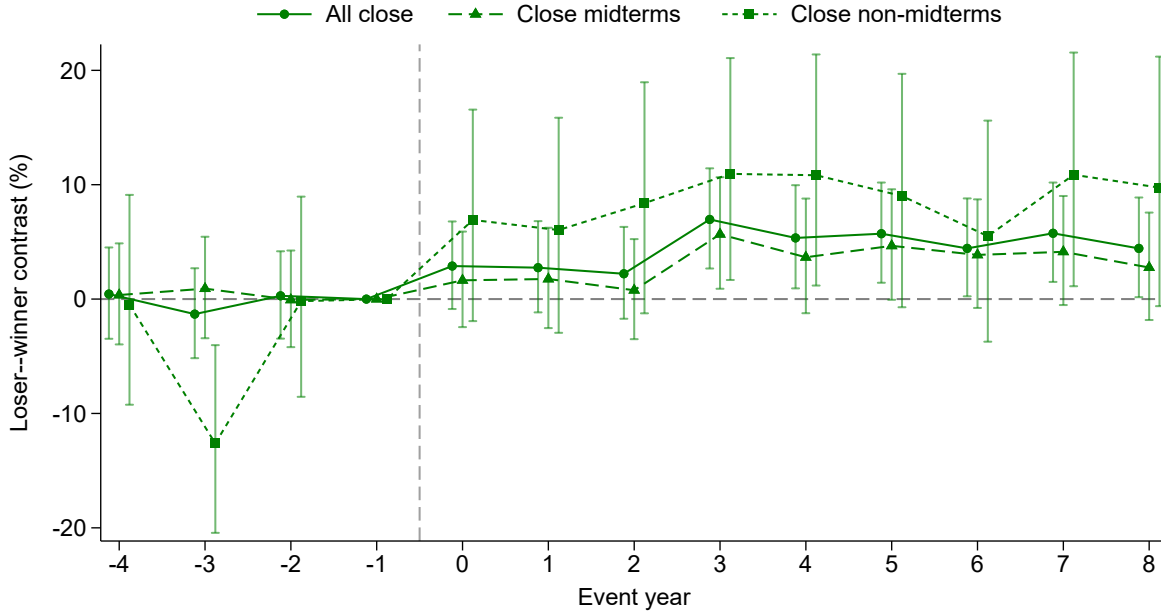
A.6 Alternative election universes

Figure A.3: Total-outmigration estimates by election timing



Notes: All specifications condition on close gubernatorial elections. The figure compares the pooled baseline with elections held in midterm years and elections held in other years. The omitted event year is -1 ; bars show 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.4: Destination-composition estimates by election timing



Notes: All specifications condition on close gubernatorial elections. The figure compares the pooled baseline with elections held in midterm years and elections held in other years. Estimates report the loser–winner destination contrast, with winner-party destinations as the omitted category. The omitted event year is -1 ; bars show 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table A.9: Total outmigration across alternative election universes

Election universe	Estimator	Elections	Observations	Effect 0–4	p-value	Effect 0–8	p-value	Pretrend p-value	Post-path p-value
All close elections	PPML	45	20,839	3.21%	0.072	3.68%	0.068	0.069	<0.001
Close midterms	PPML	29	13,429	3.57%	0.118	3.94%	0.124	0.040	<0.001
Close non-midterms	PPML	16	7,410	2.05%	0.186	2.88%	0.170	0.816	0.057
All close elections	OLS: $\ln(1+y)$	45	29,887	2.62%	0.489	2.47%	0.516	0.723	0.228

Notes: Effects are $100[\exp(\bar{\beta}) - 1]$, where $\bar{\beta}$ is the equally weighted average of the event-time coefficients over the stated horizon. The adjacent p -value tests this average. The pretrend test jointly sets the coefficients for event years -4 through -2 to zero; the post-path test jointly sets the coefficients for event years 0 through 8 to zero. The log specification uses $\ln(1 + \text{outmigration})$.

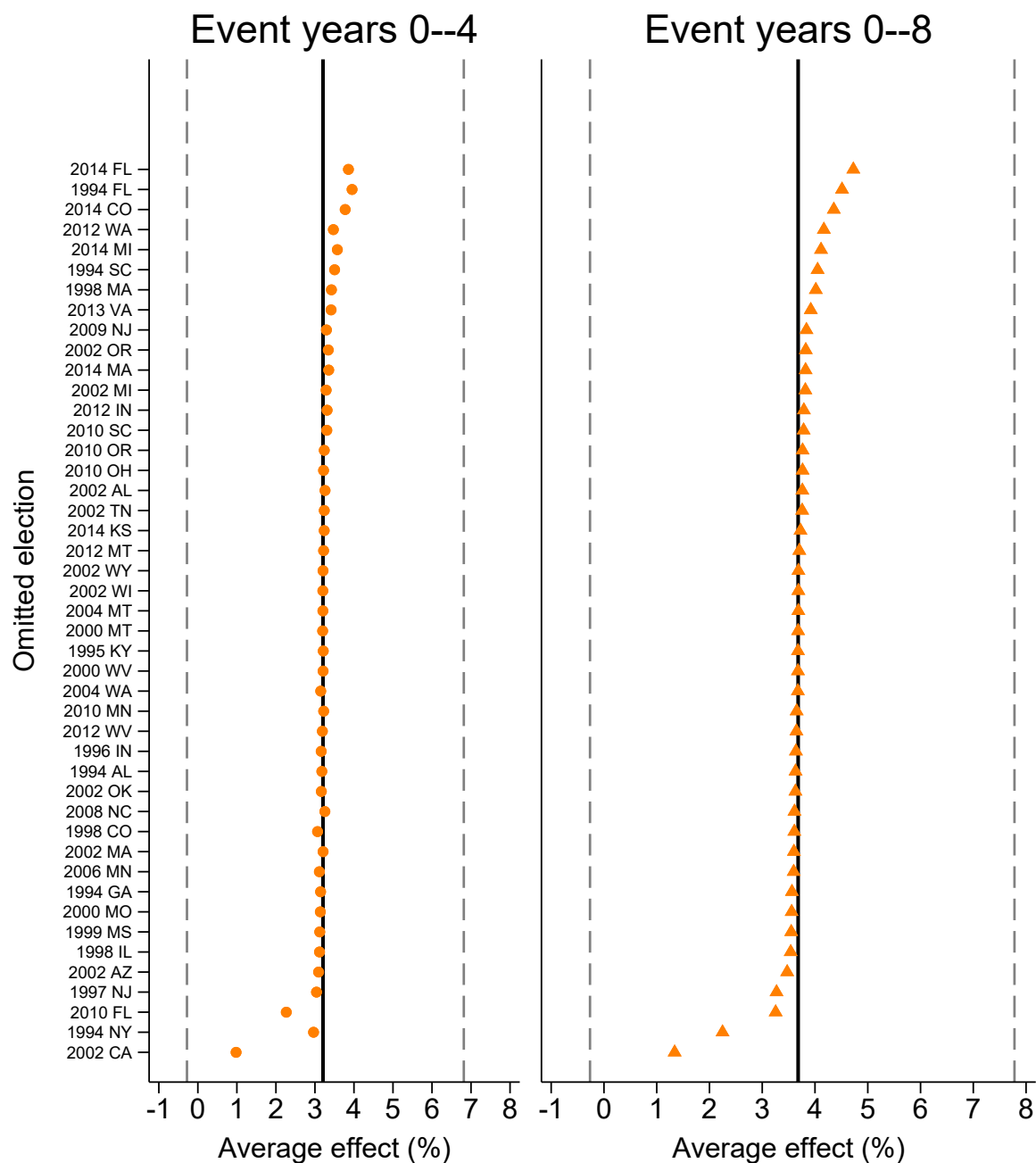
Table A.10: Destination composition across alternative election universes

Election universe	Contrast	Elections	Observations	Effect 0–4	p-value	Effect 0–8	p-value	Pretrend p-value	Post-path p-value
All close elections	Loser–winner	45	497,333	4.02%	0.015	4.49%	0.007	0.783	0.105
All close elections	Swing–winner	45	497,333	0.50%	0.689	1.03%	0.414	0.022	0.404
Close midterms	Loser–winner	29	377,960	2.68%	0.143	3.20%	0.081	0.969	0.366
Close midterms	Swing–winner	29	377,960	1.25%	0.380	1.82%	0.205	0.102	0.283
Close non-midterms	Loser–winner	16	119,373	8.61%	0.019	8.68%	0.019	0.008	0.508
Close non-midterms	Swing–winner	16	119,373	-2.23%	0.387	-1.98%	0.448	0.003	0.995

Notes: Winner-party destinations are the omitted category. Effects are $100[\exp(\bar{\beta}) - 1]$, where $\bar{\beta}$ is the equally weighted average over the stated horizon. The adjacent p -value tests this average. The pretrend test jointly sets the coefficients for event years -4 through -2 to zero; the post-path test jointly sets the coefficients for event years 0 through 8 to zero.

A.7 Leave-one-election-out validation

Figure A.5: Leave-one-election-out validation: total outmigration

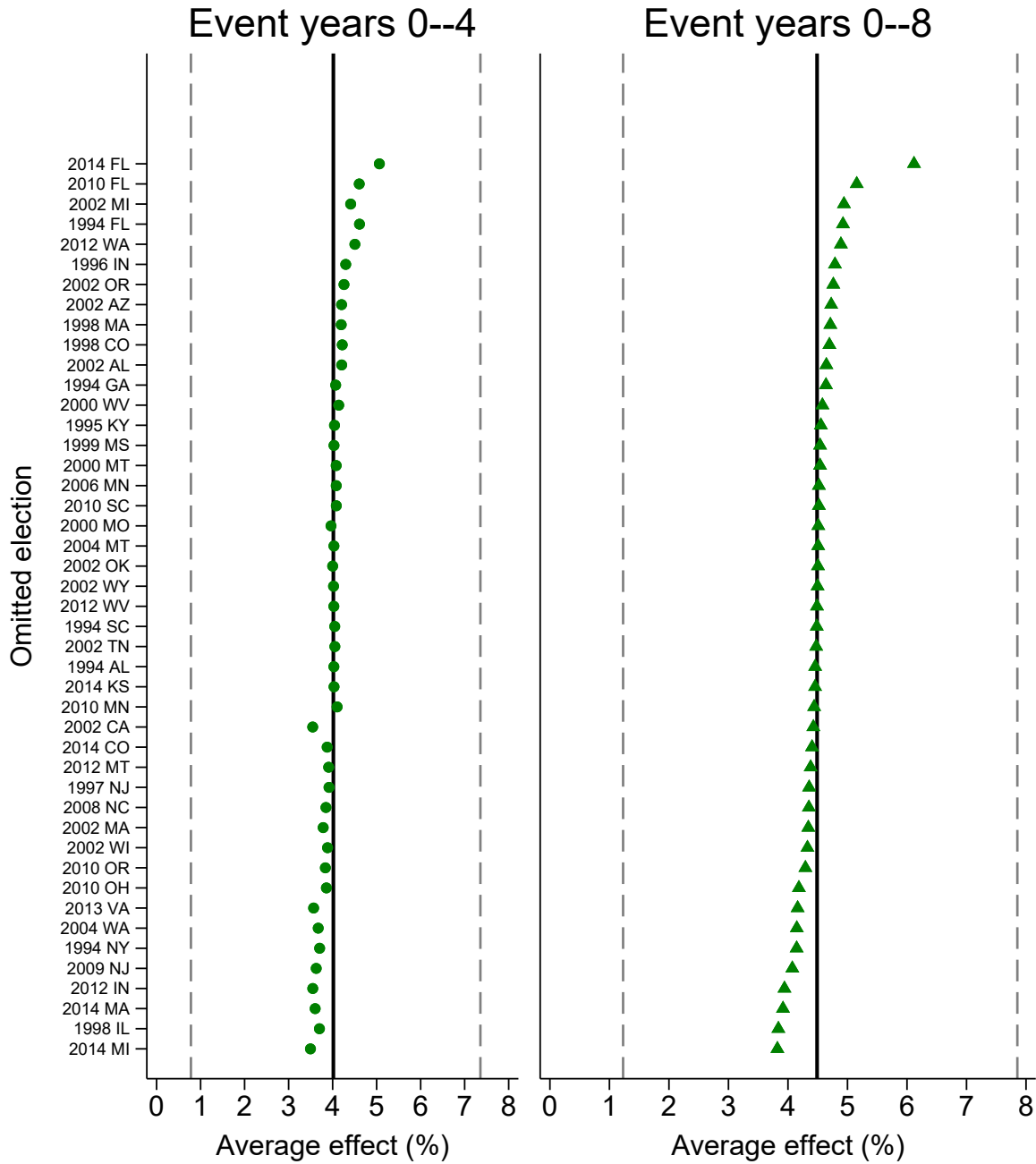


Notes: Each marker reports the level of the average estimated percent effect in the sample that omits the indicated election. The solid vertical line is the corresponding full-sample point estimate; the dashed vertical lines delimit its 95 percent confidence interval. The two panels report averages over event years 0–4 and 0–8, respectively.

The total-outmigration estimate remains positive in every leave-one-out sample. It ranges from 0.98 to 3.95 percent over event years 0–4 and from 1.34 to 4.73 percent over years 0–8. California 2002 has the greatest influence: omitting it lowers the short-horizon estimate from 3.21 to 0.98 percent. Omitting Florida 2010 lowers it to 2.27 percent, while omitting New Jersey 2009 or Florida 2014 raises it to 3.30 and 3.86 percent.

No omission reverses the sign, but inference is sensitive. Four of 45 estimates are significant at the 5 percent level over years 0–4, and six are significant over years 0–8. The pretrend test rejects in four samples.

Figure A.6: Leave-one-election-out validation: destination composition



Notes: Each marker reports the level of the average loser–winner destination contrast in the sample that omits the indicated election. Winner-party destinations remain the omitted category. The solid vertical line is the corresponding full-sample point estimate; the dashed vertical lines delimit its 95 percent confidence interval. The two panels report averages over event years 0–4 and 0–8, respectively.

The destination contrast is more stable. Across the 45 omissions, it ranges from 3.50 to 5.06 percent over years 0–4 and from 3.82 to 6.12 percent over years 0–8. Every estimate is positive and significant at the 5 percent level, and no sample rejects the joint pretrend test. The result also remains significant when Florida 2010, New Jersey 2009, or Florida 2014 is omitted; these elections do not drive the finding.

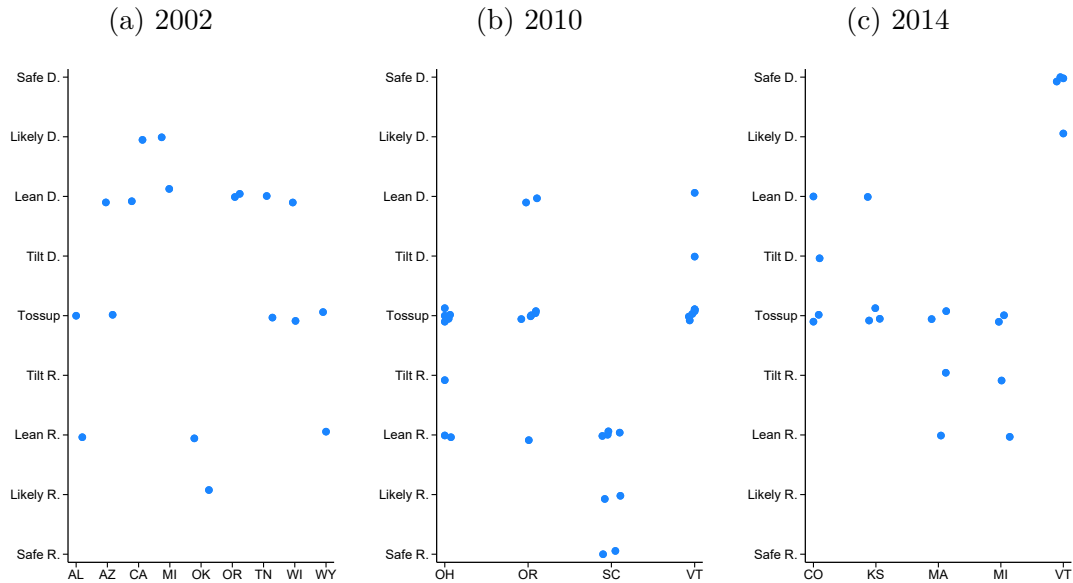
Table A.11: Summary of leave-one-election-out validation

Finding	Horizon	Full sample	LOO minimum	LOO median	LOO maximum	Positive	Significant	Pretrend rejects
Total outmigration	0–4	3.21%	0.98%	3.21%	3.95%	45/45	4/45	4/45
Total outmigration	0–8	3.68%	1.34%	3.68%	4.73%	45/45	6/45	4/45
Loser–winner destinations	0–4	4.02%	3.50%	4.03%	5.06%	45/45	45/45	0/45
Loser–winner destinations	0–8	4.49%	3.82%	4.49%	6.12%	45/45	45/45	0/45

Notes: The full-sample and leave-one-out columns report percent effects. “Positive” and “significant” count leave-one-out estimates with a positive sign and a p -value below 0.05, respectively. “Pretrend rejects” counts joint tests of event years -4 through -2 with a p -value below 0.05. Each exercise contains 45 successful omissions.

A.8 Professional election forecasts

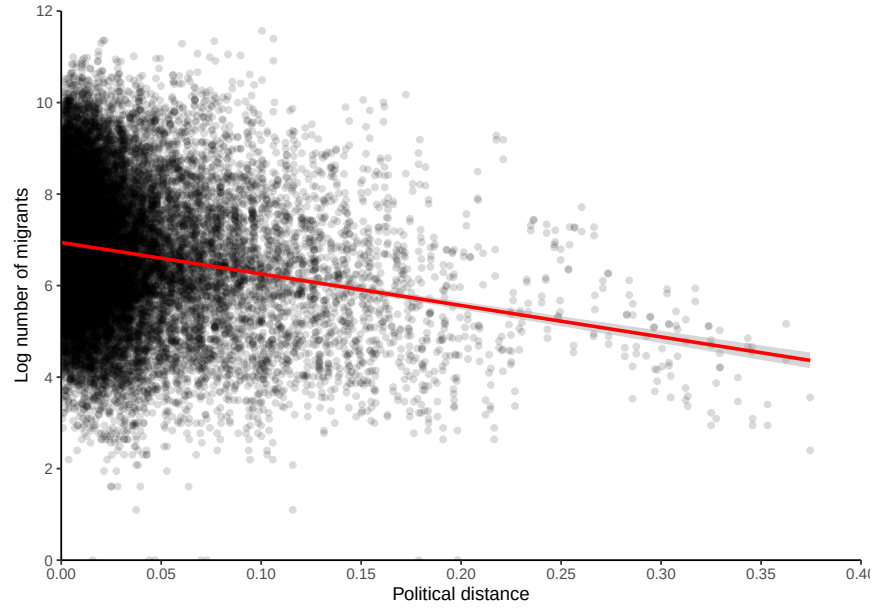
Figure A.7: Professional forecasts of gubernatorial elections



Notes: Professional pre-election ratings for gubernatorial elections in three selected years. Forecasts cover 30 of the 45 close elections in the working baseline.

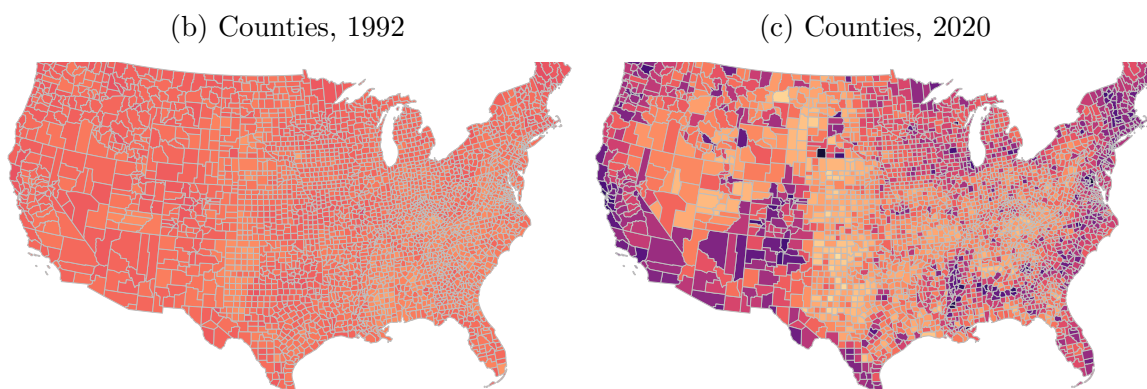
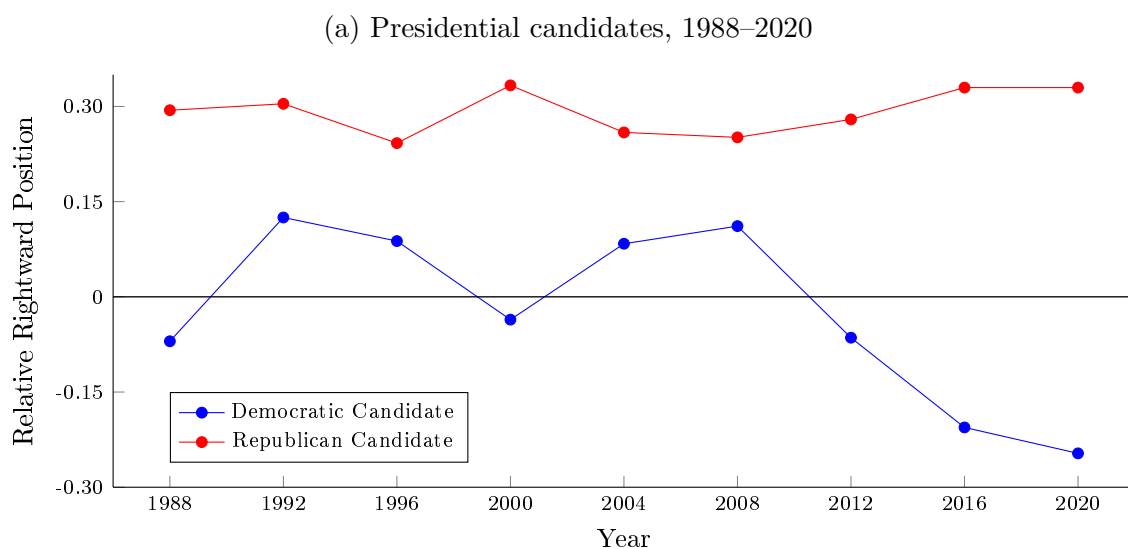
A.9 Gravity evidence

Figure A.9: Bilateral migration and political distance



Notes: Each point is a state-pair-election observation. The vertical axis reports the log bilateral migrant flow and the horizontal axis political distance. The red line shows fitted values from a bivariate linear regression.

Figure A.8: Presidential platforms and state political orientation



Notes: Panel (a) shows the Manifesto Project right–left position of the Democratic and Republican presidential candidates. Panels (b) and (c) combine those positions with local candidate vote shares. Darker shading indicates a more left-leaning political orientation.

Table A.12: Migration and political distance: robustness

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Log distance	-0.754*** (0.026)	-0.754*** (0.026)	-0.757*** (0.026)	-0.756*** (0.026)	-0.716*** (0.026)
Contiguity	0.735*** (0.052)	0.735*** (0.052)	0.741*** (0.053)	0.740*** (0.053)	0.667*** (0.050)
Political Distance	-2.703*** (0.475)	-2.703*** (0.475)	-2.713*** (0.474)	-2.703*** (0.478)	-1.282** (0.501)
Opponents in CW	0.189*** (0.042)				
NU to Conf.		0.196*** (0.072)			
Conf. to NU		0.180*** (0.063)			
Allies in CW			-0.194*** (0.044)		
NU to NU				-0.211*** (0.067)	
Conf. to Conf.				-0.173*** (0.065)	
Coast to coast					0.444*** (0.063)
Observations	19600	19600	19600	19600	19600
Origin-Time FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Destination-Time FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Pseudo R ²	0.926	0.926	0.926	0.926	0.929

Notes: The dependent variable is the bilateral flow of individuals in the year after a presidential election. Specifications add indicators for whether the states were opponents or allies during the Civil War, directional historical-alignment indicators, and a coast-to-coast indicator. All models include origin-year and destination-year fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by state pair. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.